Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 4.3 Guided Notes: Psychology of Social Situations

Unit 4: Social Psychology and Personality | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic4.3

Word Bank

Obedience	*Conformity*	*Line Experiment*
Informational Social Influence	*Shock Experiment*	*Social Influence Theory*
Normative Social Influence	*Social Norms*	*Stanford Prison Experiment*

1. Social Influence: Conformity and Obedience

Do you act differently when you are hanging out with your friends compared to when you are sitting in a silent classroom? Of course you do! _____ define expectations and roles a society may have for its members in individual and social situations.

The Power of Roles

Before we even get to persuasion or peer pressure, the social situation itself can shape behavior through the roles it hands us. A role is a set of expectations about how people in a specific social position should behave — and when we step into a new role, we often adopt its attitudes surprisingly fast.

The most famous (and highly controversial) demonstration of this was Philip Zimbardo's _____. College students randomly assigned to be “guards” or “prisoners” quickly adopted the aggressive or submissive attitudes expected of those roles, taking the simulation so seriously that the experiment had to be shut down early. It revealed a striking truth: the social situation, not just personality, can override how we normally behave.

_____ proposes that social pressure to behave or think in certain ways can be normative or informational. Depending on the situation, we bend to the group for different reasons:

- _____: The tendency to conform in order to be liked, accepted, or approved of by others, even if we do not privately agree with the group. (e.g., You secretly hate the taste of iced coffee, but you order it anyway because all your friends are drinking it.)
- _____: The tendency to conform because we believe others have accurate information, especially in ambiguous or uncertain situations. (e.g., You travel to a foreign country and are unsure how to use the subway system, so you closely copy the behavior of the locals.)

Apply It: Normative or Informational?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Unsure which fork to use at a formal dinner, a guest watches what the other diners do and copies them.	
2	A student laughs at a joke he doesn't find funny because everyone else at the table is laughing and he doesn't want to seem out of place.	
3	A hiker reaches an unmarked trail split and follows a large group heading left, assuming they know the way.	
4	A boy wears a brand of sneakers he thinks are ugly because the popular kids all wear them and he wants them to accept him.	

Famous Conformity & Obedience Research

Research on _____ clarifies the conditions that strengthen the likelihood of people adhering to unspoken rules, norms, or expectations. The most famous demonstration of this is Solomon Asch's _____, where participants routinely agreed with a group's obviously incorrect answer about the length of drawn lines just to avoid standing out. In this classic study, about 33% of participants agreed with the group's clearly incorrect answer at least once, even though the correct answer was obvious.

When the pressure comes from the top down, we look at _____—a form of social influence in which individuals follow direct commands or orders from an authority figure. Research on this form of influence clarifies the conditions that strengthen the likelihood of people complying with the directives of an authority figure. Stanley Milgram's _____ is the cornerstone study here. Participants believed they were administering painful electric shocks to a learner just because an experimenter in a lab coat told them to continue. This study revealed shocking truths about human nature, but also led to strict modern ethical guidelines in psychological research due to the severe psychological distress it caused the participants.

Apply It: Which Study or Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A researcher seats a volunteer at a table with several actors who all confidently give the same obviously wrong answer about which line matches a standard line.	
2	At a concert, a man starts standing and clapping along with the song only because everyone around him is doing it.	
3	Volunteers who believe they are giving painful electric shocks to a learner keep going whenever a researcher in a lab coat tells them to continue.	
4	A new hire stays late to file reports because his supervisor directly orders him to.	
5	College students randomly assigned to play guards and prisoners in a mock jail begin acting harshly or submissively, and the study is ended early.	

Word Bank

Collectivism	*Group Polarization*	*Central Route to Persuasion*
Social Inhibition	*Social Loafing*	*Groupthink*
Social Facilitation	*Persuasion*	*Multiculturalism*
Halo Effect	*Elaboration Likelihood Model*	*Door-in-the-Face Technique*
Individualism	*Peripheral Route to Persuasion*	*Deindividuation*
Foot-in-the-Door Technique		

2. Persuasion Techniques

_____ refers to the techniques applied to convince the self or others of particular ideas, actions, or beliefs. It can depend on the route taken. The _____ outlines two main routes to persuasion: central and peripheral.

- _____: People carefully analyze and think about the quality of the arguments being presented. (e.g., Buying a car based on its safety ratings and fuel efficiency.)
- _____: People are influenced by superficial cues such as attractiveness, emotion, or credibility of the source. (e.g., Buying a car because a famous celebrity was driving it in a catchy commercial.) The _____ (where an overall positive impression of a person influences perceptions of their other traits) is a prime example of this route.

Additionally, persuasion can depend on how information is presented, as demonstrated by two classic techniques:

- _____: Agreeing to a small request makes someone more likely to agree to a larger related request later. (e.g., Asking to borrow $5, then later asking to borrow $50.)
- _____: Making a massive, unreasonable request that gets rejected, followed by a smaller, more reasonable request. (e.g., Asking your parents for a brand new car, and when they say no, asking if you can at least borrow theirs for the weekend.)

Apply It: Which Persuasion Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A voter studies each candidate's budget plan and voting record before deciding whom to support.	
2	A shopper picks a brand of sunscreen because the ad features a well-known, charming actor and has a catchy jingle.	
3	A teacher assumes that an attractive, well-dressed new student must also be smart and hard-working.	
4	A neighbor first asks to put a small sign on your lawn, and weeks later asks if she can paint a large mural on your fence.	
5	A fundraiser asks a passerby for a $500 donation, and when he refuses, she asks if he would give just $10.	

3. Group Dynamics and Behavior

Being a member of a group can profoundly influence how one behaves or experiences mental processes. Here is how the presence of others changes our cognitive wiring:

- Performing a mental or physical behavior in front of a group can lead to _____. This means you perform better on simple or well-practiced tasks when others are present. Conversely, _____ means performing worse on difficult or unpracticed tasks under a crowd's gaze.
- _____: The tendency for individuals to put in less effort when working in a group compared to when working alone. (e.g., Coasting through a group project because you know your partners will do the heavy lifting.)
- _____: A state in which individuals lose self-awareness and personal accountability in a group, making them more likely to act in ways they normally would not (often seen in riots or online anonymity).
- _____: The tendency for group discussion to strengthen the initial attitudes of group members, leading them to make more extreme decisions.
- _____: A phenomenon in which a desire for group harmony leads members to suppress dissenting opinions and make flawed or irrational decisions.

Our cultural background also shapes our group behavior. Cultural phenomena such as _____ (focusing on personal goals), _____ (focusing on group harmony), and _____ can influence how one perceives and behaves towards oneself and others.

Apply It: Which Group Dynamic?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A chess master who has played thousands of games makes sharper moves when a crowd gathers to watch.	
2	A student who is still learning long division fumbles a problem at the board while the whole class watches, though he solved similar problems easily at his desk.	
3	In a group project, a student contributes very little because she knows her teammates will cover the work and no one will notice her individual effort.	
4	Hidden behind anonymous usernames, commenters in an online forum pile onto a stranger with insults they would never say face to face.	
5	After discussing a controversial issue only with friends who share his view, a man leaves the conversation holding an even more extreme opinion than when he arrived.	
6	A planning committee, eager to keep everyone happy, quickly approves a risky plan without raising objections or considering alternatives.	

Word Bank

Diffusion of Responsibility	*False Consensus Effect*	*Social Responsibility Norm*
Superordinate Goals	*Prosocial Behavior*	*Robbers Cave Experiment*
Industrial-Organizational (I/O) Psychologists	*Social Reciprocity Norm*	*Bystander Effect*
Social Traps	*Altruism*	

3. Group Dynamics, Continued: Conflict and Cooperation

People often overestimate the levels to which others agree with them, known as the _____. This can lead to conflict. _____ occur when individuals do not unite and act in their own self-interest to the detriment of the group. However, harmony can be restored. _____ serve to unite disparate groups under a common goal and help reduce negative affect and stereotyping among groups. Muzafer Sherif proved this in his famous _____, where two rival groups of boys only set aside their intense hatred for one another when they had to work together to fix the camp's water supply.

Curious about how this applies to the real world? _____ study how people perform in the workplace. They study best practices in management of work, relationships among people working together, and how people feel about work (such as burnout).

Apply It: Conflict and Cooperation

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A man is convinced that nearly everyone agrees with his unpopular opinion about a movie, and he is shocked when a poll shows most people disagree.	
2	Every fisherman on a lake catches as many fish as he can to benefit himself, until the lake is nearly empty and no one can catch anything.	
3	Two rival schools' student councils set aside their feud and work together to organize a hurricane-relief drive.	
4	In a classic summer-camp study, rival groups of boys developed intense hostility, then reconciled once they had to cooperate to solve a shared problem.	
5	A company hires a psychologist to study why employees are burning out and how managers can better organize their teams' work.	

4. Prosocial Behavior and the Bystander Effect

Why do we help others? _____ involves voluntary actions intended to benefit others. _____ refers to truly selfless behavior, but some researchers suggest that people help others because they have incurred social debt. For instance, the _____ (the expectation to return a favor) and the _____ (the expectation to help those in need) explain this type of behavior.

However, we do not always help. The tragic case of Kitty Genovese inspired researchers Latané and Darley to study the _____. This effect demonstrates that situational and attentional variables predict whether someone is likely to help another person. The primary cause is the _____—the tendency for individuals to feel less personally responsible for taking action when other people are present.

Apply It: Which Helping Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A coworker brings donuts for the whole office, an action meant to benefit others, though she also enjoys the thanks she receives.	
2	An anonymous donor pays for a stranger's surgery and never reveals her name or expects anything in return.	
3	After a neighbor watches her dog for a week, a woman feels she should do something nice for him in return and brings him a pie.	
4	A man gives up his bus seat to a visibly exhausted stranger because he feels people should help those in need.	
5	Latané and Darley's research found that people were less likely to help someone in need when more bystanders were present.	

📺 *Video Notes: "Social Influence" (Crash Course Psychology #38)*

This video covers obedience, conformity, and group dynamics. It doesn't cover persuasion techniques, the bystander effect, or conflict and cooperation, so use the sections above for those. Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. What led Stanley Milgram to design his obedience experiment, and how was it set up?

2. What were the results of Milgram's first experiment, and what conditions did he later find made people more obedient?

3. How does the video define conformity, and how did Solomon Asch's experiment test it?

4. According to the video, what makes people more likely to conform, and what is normative social influence?

5. How does the video describe social facilitation and social loafing, and what examples does it give?

6. What do deindividuation, group polarization, and groupthink mean in the video, and what examples or effects does it give for each?

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Conformity vs. Obedience: _____ involves changing behavior to fit in with peers or a group. _____ involves changing behavior in response to a direct command from an authority figure. If a teacher tells you to be quiet, that is the second. If you become quiet because the rest of the class is quiet, that is the first.

⚠️ Group Polarization vs. Groupthink: _____ is about the strengthening of an attitude (the group gets more extreme in their views after talking). _____ is about a flawed decision-making process where people stop raising objections just to keep the group happy and conflict-free.

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A teenager secretly dislikes the taste of a trendy energy drink but orders it anyway every time she's out with her friend group, purely because she doesn't want to feel left out or judged by them. This type of conformity, driven by a desire to be liked and accepted, is called:

- **A.** Obedience
- **B.** Normative Social Influence
- **C.** Groupthink
- **D.** Informational Social Influence

2. A teacher tells her noisy classroom, "Everyone needs to be quiet right now," and the students immediately comply with her direct command. According to the distinction between conformity and obedience, this student behavior is best classified as:

- **A.** Conformity, because the students are simply copying each other's quiet behavior
- **B.** Normative Social Influence, because the students want to be liked by their teacher
- **C.** Groupthink, because the class is avoiding conflict with one another
- **D.** Obedience, because it is a response to a direct command from an authority figure

3. A customer decides to purchase a specific brand of laptop only after carefully reading multiple in-depth reviews comparing processing speed, battery life, and build quality across several competing models. This method of persuasion, which relies on carefully analyzing the quality of the arguments presented, is called the:

- **A.** Door-in-the-Face Technique
- **B.** Central Route to Persuasion
- **C.** Peripheral Route to Persuasion
- **D.** Foot-in-the-Door Technique

4. After learning that a financial advisor graduated from a prestigious university, a client automatically assumes he must also be trustworthy, honest, and highly competent in every other aspect of his job, despite having no actual evidence of these other traits. This tendency for an overall positive impression to influence perceptions of unrelated traits is called the:

- **A.** Foot-in-the-Door Technique
- **B.** False Consensus Effect
- **C.** Door-in-the-Face Technique
- **D.** Halo Effect

5. A teenager first asks his parents if he can borrow their car for an entire month-long road trip, and when they immediately and firmly refuse this unreasonable request, he quickly follows up by asking if he could at least borrow the car for just this coming weekend instead. This persuasion technique, which uses an unreasonable initial request to increase compliance with a smaller one, is called:

- **A.** The Halo Effect
- **B.** Groupthink
- **C.** Door-in-the-Face Technique
- **D.** Foot-in-the-Door Technique

6. A runner who normally jogs at a moderate, comfortable pace finds herself running noticeably faster and with more energy during a competitive race with a crowd of spectators watching, since running is already a well-practiced skill for her. This improved performance on a simple, well-practiced task while being watched is called:

- **A.** Deindividuation
- **B.** Social Facilitation
- **C.** Social Inhibition
- **D.** Social Loafing

7. While participating in an anonymous, large, and chaotic crowd during a riot, a normally calm and law-abiding man finds himself throwing rocks and shouting aggressively, engaging in destructive behaviors he would never even consider doing if he were alone and clearly identifiable. This loss of self-awareness and personal accountability within a group is called:

- **A.** Groupthink
- **B.** Group Polarization
- **C.** Social Loafing
- **D.** Deindividuation

8. After a stranger unexpectedly picks up and returns a wallet a man accidentally dropped on the street, the man feels a strong internal urge to somehow repay this kindness in the future, even in a completely unrelated situation. This expectation to return a favor received from someone else is called the:

- **A.** Social Reciprocity Norm
- **B.** Social Responsibility Norm
- **C.** Diffusion of Responsibility
- **D.** The Bystander Effect

9. A passerby stops to help an elderly stranger who has fallen on the sidewalk, not because he expects anything in return or owes the stranger any favor, but simply because he feels a general moral obligation to assist someone who is vulnerable and in need. This expectation to help those in need, regardless of any personal connection, is called the:

- **A.** Social Reciprocity Norm
- **B.** Social Responsibility Norm
- **C.** The False Consensus Effect
- **D.** Altruism Exclusively, with No Other Possible Motive

10. During a medical emergency on a crowded city street with dozens of witnesses standing around, each individual bystander assumes that surely someone else in the large crowd has already called for help, so no single person actually takes action themselves. This tendency to feel less personally responsible for helping when other people are present is called:

- **A.** Group Polarization
- **B.** The Social Reciprocity Norm
- **C.** Social Loafing
- **D.** Diffusion of Responsibility

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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